

MANAGING STRESS AT GRADUATE SCHOOL

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Managing stress at graduate school

Self-reflective questions

1. What situations are the most stressful for me as a student?
2. How does stress affect me (physically, psychologically, etc.)?
3. What do I do to cope with stress? Which coping mechanisms are the most/least effective for me?
4. What other strategies and techniques would I like to try?

What is “stress”?

A stressful situation has little to do with your emotional response. It is your **appraisal** of the situation and **how** you interpret your own body’s response that creates your anxiety. In other words, it is your thoughts about a situation which is the critical factor in evaluating whether you ‘feel stressed.’

Common stressors affecting students

- Lack of time
- Availability of resources
- Finances
- Unclear expectations e.g. assignments, how to study for tests
- For international students: language, homesickness, adjustment stress, loneliness and isolation, lack of social support

Specific stressors affecting graduate students

- Scholarships: finishing thesis before scholarship money runs out Multiple and competing roles and responsibilities Communication with supervisors, colleagues
- Unrealistic expectations e.g. thesis completion deadline
- Heavy workload e.g. being a T.A./R.A. while doing own research
- Presentations: conferences, thesis defence, seminars

Common reactions to high levels of stress

- Distractibility, loss of focus and concentration
- Irritability
- Tension in the body and/or somatic illnesses
- Avoidance/procrastination
- Exhaustion, lethargy
- Loss of self-confidence, self-esteem
- Sadness, low mood

Multiple life stressors

Research has shown that stressful life events can lead to serious mental health issues such as depression.¹ Students can be at risk as their lives are very complicated and pressured. Be aware of your stressors and how they are impacting you. Attend to your stressors when you feel that your mood is being adversely affected. For international students, life stress is an important factor in cultural adjustment that is moderately related to the development of mental illness.² If adjusting to Queen's and Canadian society is causing you emotional hardship, consider consulting the cross-cultural counsellor at [Queen's Counselling Service](#) or at [Queen's University International Centre](#).

Overview of module content

- I. [Self-Awareness](#)
- II. [The Stress Response](#)
- III. [A Model of Stress Reduction](#)
- IV. [Body Relaxation Strategies](#)
- V. [Mind Relaxation Strategies](#)
- VI. [Mindfulness Based Stress Reduction](#)

We have also included additional information and hands-on tools at the end of the module.

¹ See Brown, G. W., Bifulco, A., & Harris, T. O. (1987). Life event, vulnerability, and onset of depression: Some refinements. *British Journal of Psychiatry*, 150, 30-42.

Bulmash, E. L. (2007). *Personality, stressful life events, and treatment response in major depression*. Master's Thesis. Queen's University, Kingston, Ontario, Canada.

² Yang, B. & Clum, G.S. (1994). Life stress, social support, and problem-solving skills predictive of depressive symptoms, hopelessness, and suicide ideation in an Asian student population: A test of a model. *Suicide & Life-Threatening Behaviour*, 24(2). 127.

I. Self-awareness

Self-reflection questions

- How stressed do I feel right now?
- How does stress manifest in my body?
- I am dealing well with my life stress? Why/ why not?
- What coping mechanisms do I have/ use to manage stressful situations?

The first step to managing your stress is to understand what part it plays in your life.

How stressed am I? Take a stress test.

Several organizations offer versions of a stress test. The Canadian Mental Health Association (CMHA) offers one good [stress test](#). For more information about stress from CMHA, see the [CMHA stress website](#).

My stress symptoms

Over the next few days, observe your body's physical reaction to stress. Notice subtle signals you might have overlooked before. Ask friends or family what they notice when you're stressed: do they notice signs you haven't?

Self-care checklist

Taking care of oneself is fundamental to a happy, healthy, low stress life. Assess your level of self-care using the tool [How Well Am I Taking Care of Myself?](#)

Tension diary

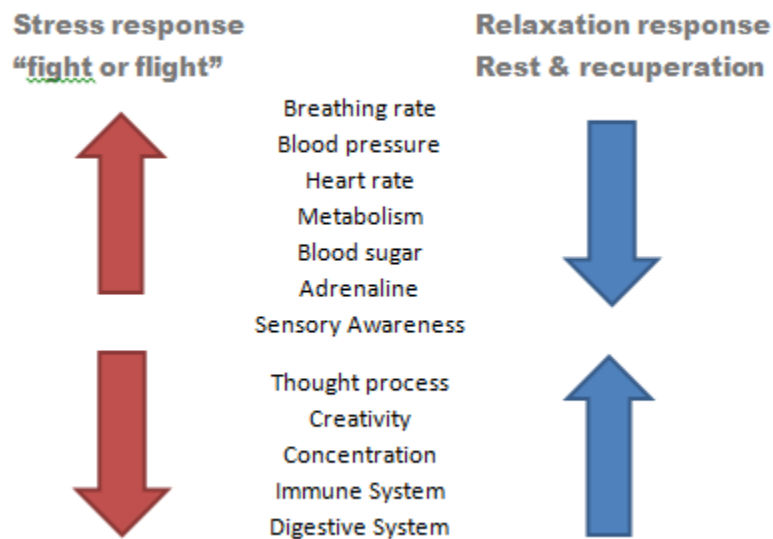
Become aware of what increases your stress and any strategies you use to help decrease your stress. Monitor your stress by using [the Tension Diary](#).

II. The stress response: How our body responds to stress

After thousands of years of human evolution, our bodies still respond to stress in the same way as our ancestors. During the stress response, also known as the 'fight or flight' response, your nervous system is turned on (see symptoms in Figure 1 below) releasing stress hormones and preparing for battle or escape. Meanwhile, your immune and digestive systems and your cognitive processes slow down. Conversely, during the relaxation response your nervous system slows down so you are able to think more clearly and creatively. Your immune and digestive systems function better.

Although we still need both responses for human survival, the historical value of the stress response (e.g. when the tiger is at your cave door, you either run or slug it over the head with your club) no longer applies. Our modern stressors – academic, workplace, and relationships – do not allow us to release tension through physical action and the stress builds up. With prolonged exposure to stress hormones, it is the stress response **itself** that causes damage to the body. The good news is that the stress response and the relaxation response are **opposite** and **mutually exclusive**. That means if you induce the relaxation response, your stress response will be shut off.

Figure One: Symptoms of Stress versus Relaxation Response



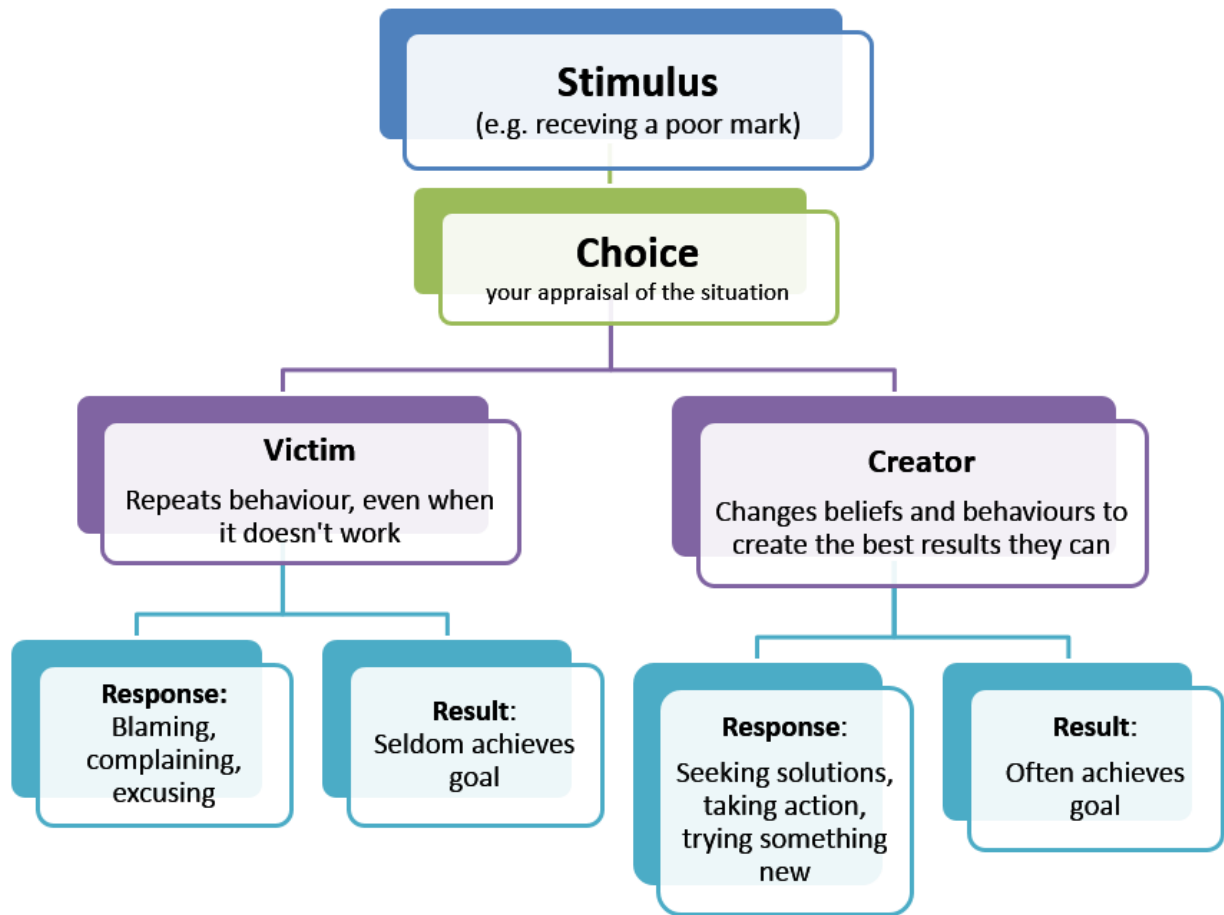
Prolonged stress is BAD NEWS!

- More susceptible to illnesses
- Irritability, exhaustion and burn-out
- Can lead to depressed mood

III. A model of stress reduction: taking on the Creator Role

Figure 2 below describes two different responses to the same stimulus: one negative (The Victim), the other positive (The Creator). The former response may increase stress while the latter response may reduce stress. Because the Creator chooses a problem-solving, action based solution, he/she feels more in control and, therefore, less stressed.

Figure 2: Adopting the Creator Role of Stress Reduction



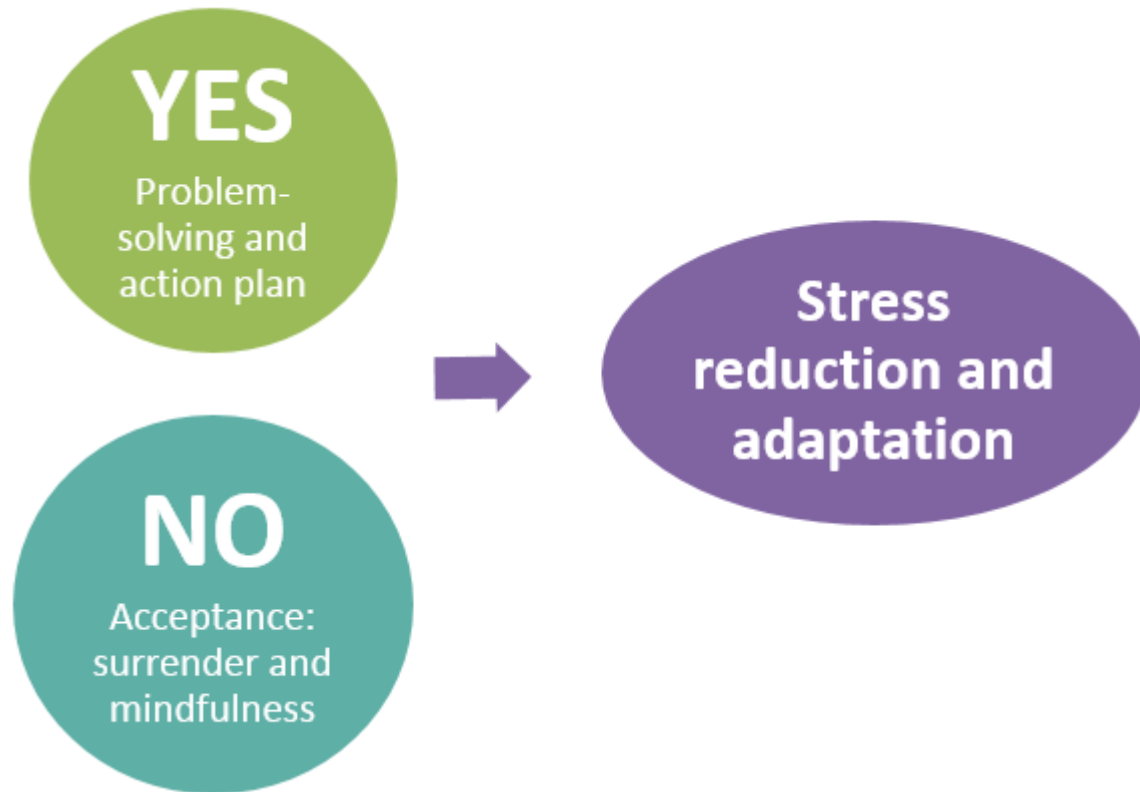
Creators...

- Believe they **create** everything in their lives
- Accept responsibility for creating one's own results
- Responsibility = making choice
- Make choices to influence the outcomes of their lives

Figure 3 demonstrates how someone who takes on a Creator role reduces stress. Firstly, he/she asks whether this problem can be solved or not. If yes, the Creator gets on with the business of working through the problem. Engaging the mind in solving the problem overshadows the

worries and fear which, in turn, helps the mind relax. However, even during problem-solving there might be some residual stress that needs attention and this is where having good stress management strategies can help. If you have little or no control over the stress-provoking situation, a Creator accepts the way things are at present while continuing to use stress management techniques and positive thinking.

Figure 3: Can I do something about the stress provoking situation?



Problem-Solving: What do I need to do to change this situation?

Acceptance: How can I learn to accept that some things cannot be changed now or maybe ever?

Stress Reduction: What techniques and strategies can I use to reduce and cope with stress?

Adaptation: What positive attitudes and behaviours do I need to prepare for future events?

Stress and anxiety management strategies

For the greatest de-stressing effect, relax both your body and your mind! See [10 Ways to Relax](#).

IV. Ways to relax the body

Deep breathing

Deep breathing is one of the best techniques for relieving stress. When you're under stress, your muscles tense and your breathing gets shallow and rapid as you breathe higher in the chest. You can stop this stress response by breathing deeply and slowly from the diaphragm or abdomen. It sounds simple and IT IS! Follow the steps in our tool [Take a Deep Breath and Relax!](#)

Progressive muscle relaxation

Progressive muscle relaxation (PMR) increases your awareness of body tension versus relaxation and is a tool to induce a relaxed state. During PMR you tense then relax targeted muscle groups. The tensing and relaxing over 3-5 repetitions slowly forces the muscles into a state of relaxation. Imagine gently pulling a fresh elastic band until it's taut and then releasing it. It starts out very stiff and hard to pull; however, after several stretches the elastic becomes more pliable and elongates. This is what happens when you employ PMR to your tense muscles. Read [Progressive Muscle Relaxation – Script](#).

Stretching

Graduate students tend to sit a great deal during the day, reading and writing. Muscles, especially the neck, shoulders, and lower back can take a beating. Combine stress with this sedentary picture and you have a recipe for muscle tension. It's good to take many mini power breaks of 5-10 minutes throughout the day to stretch out.

Yoga is also an excellent way to learn how to combine stretching (postures or asanas) with breathing for full body relaxation. Yoga classes are offered at Queen's University, the YMCA of Kingston, and at many private yoga studios throughout the city.

See [Do-anywhere Stretching Exercises](#) for some easy stretching exercises, many of which you can do in your office, lab, or library.

For more exercises, see [Whole Fitness](#).

Visualization

Close your eyes and visualize a serene, comforting place e.g. a beach, a forest. Use all your senses to savour this place: what do you see, smell, hear, taste, and feel? Prepared scripts are fine, but it's more powerful to use your own imagery which has meaning to you. For a prepared visualization, see [Visualization: Springtime in the Forest](#).

Guilt-free play

Little kids know how to relax—they play. Adults who take time for **guilt-free** play on a regular basis are happier, more energetic, have better interpersonal relationships, etc. Workaholics, on the other hand, can suffer from burn-out, become resentful, and have less time to nurture friendships and family ties. Grad students can sometimes get into a workaholic rut, especially when large deadlines loom. At these times more than ever, you need to schedule ‘play’ into your week. Play helps you clear your head and allows ideas to percolate in the background which is important when you are working on complex, complicated projects. Play leads to higher levels of quality and creative work. So, get out there and PLAY today!

Suggested Resource: Neil Fiore’s 2007 edition of *The NOW Habit: A strategic program for overcoming procrastination and enjoying guilt-free play*.

Music

Music can relax and heal, particularly serene, soothing music. There are many free music streaming services on the internet, or you can buy music online or at a CD store. Try searching for “relaxation music.”

Laugh

Laughing releases endorphins, the ‘feel-good’ hormones. So watch a funny movie or share a joke. Changing a frown into a smile, even when you don’t feel like it, can improve your mood.

Eye movements to reduce stress

In his bestseller book *Mega Memory*, Kevin Trudeau describes an eye movement technique to help reduce stress. Try it! See [Using Eye Movements to Reduce Stress & Improve Recall](#).

Get a good night’s sleep

What if I’m wound up just before bedtime?

- Take a warm bath.
- Count sheep! Slow, repetitive cycles of counting can calm your mind and body. Drink warm milk or calming teas (milk contains an enzyme that makes you sleepy).
- Stop studying at least one hour before bedtime (but you can read a book for pleasure).
- Turn off electronic equipment a couple hours before bedtime. The electro-magnetic waves from computers, etc. stimulate your brain, not help it relax.
- Do gentle stretches, breathing, and/or meditation. Have a light, low-fat snack.
- Avoid caffeine, alcohol, cigarettes.
- Develop a regular sleep-wake routine so your body anticipates your cycle.

See [12 Rules for Better Sleep Hygiene](#).

V. Ways to relax the mind

1. Reframing negative thoughts

Self-talk

We all have a voice in our head that talks to us. This 'self-talk' includes the internal dialogues or silent conversations that go on within our minds most of the time and can be either positive, negative, or neutral. These dialogues often create self-fulfilling prophesies. For example, if you tell yourself you are relaxed and happy, we will start to feel better. In turn, if you continuously tell yourself you are stressed out, you will feel frazzled. In other words, we create our own stress! Some people don't like to face this truth; they prefer to blame their feelings on the external world (e.g. my boss/spouse/kid/etc. **makes me** feel...**my job is** so awful/ boring/ unfulfilling etc.).

See [How Self Talk Affects Stress](#) and [Identifying Your Stress-Inducing Self Talk](#).

Reframing

The good news is that we can 'reframe' negative thoughts into more positive, helpful ones. For most of us, our minds won't readily accept a new, positive thought, especially if the existing negative thought is well entrenched. So we need to design meaningful thoughts and practice them regularly until the new thought becomes the norm. Here are a few suggestions to guide you:

a) Affirmations/mantras

Create a positive affirmation or mantra of the new thought, post it somewhere very visible, and repeat it many times until your mind starts to 'buy into' the reframed thought. For example, imagine you've been telling yourself that your dissertation is just too big for you to manage and you'll never finish on time. The outcome is that you start to feel overwhelmed, procrastinate, and avoid using effective time management. Instead, try saying: "I can take one small step each day" or "I am capable of completing this task well." Repeat this statement as a mantra.

b) Thought Record

Developed by psychologists Dennis Greenberger and Christina Padesky, the *Thought Record* helps you identify problematic thoughts or images, assess the veracity of the thought, and develop a more adaptive, balanced thought. The *Thought Record* has proven over the course of time to be a very powerful tool in helping people reframe negative thoughts and improve mood.

See [Using a Thought Record](#).

2. Stress Inoculation Training (SIT): Imagery, relaxation, and using coping statements

Stress Inoculation Training (SIT) was developed by psychologist Donald Meichenbaum in 1977. While other stress reduction programs aimed at mastering anxiety, Meichenbaum felt that being anxiety-free is unrealistic; anxiety can creep back in over time or new anxieties can form. Instead, he taught people how to **cope** with their anxiety, anywhere, anytime. SIT involves learning how to relax deeply and use coping thoughts as you visualize anxiety-provoking scenarios, starting from your least stressful scenarios and working up a hierarchy to your most feared. In traditional SIT the client would stick with the stressful situation no matter how unpleasant. However, in recent years Meichenbaum's technique has been modified so that people can shut the scene off if their anxiety goes too high (see *The Anxiety and Phobia Workbook*, 1995). It is the combination of **relaxation** and **coping thoughts** which makes this technique most effective.

For a full description of the SIT procedure, a list of coping statements, and an example, see [Stress Inoculation Training](#) and A Grad Student Scenario Using Stress Induction.

3. Imagining new behaviour

We can all learn a new pattern of thinking or behaviour by observing and imitating others. Ideally, try to find a good role model who effectively manages life's stressors. Is there someone in your department who, although he/she has so much to do, always seems to be calm and in control? Ask what strategies he/she uses. Try testing these strategies in your own life.

“Covert” modelling

Unfortunately, good models are sometimes hard to find. A technique called ‘covert modelling’ involves **imagining yourself** as a model of stress management. Once you can SEE yourself relaxing and being in control in your mind, you will be able to translate this into real life behaviour. Due to its unfamiliarity, you might find this difficult and awkward at first, so start with an easy scenario and work up to the really difficult ones. For example, if meeting your supervisor face-to-face causes huge anxiety, then start by imagining yourself calmly interacting with the supervisor over the phone.

4. Acceptance

When we can't change our situation, learning to let go will reduce your stress considerably. The serenity prayer encapsulates the wisdom of acceptance:

Grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, Courage to change the things I can and the Wisdom to know the difference.

See [Ways to Acceptance](#).

VII. Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction

What is mindfulness?

Mindfulness is bringing our full attention to the present. Mindfulness is observing the mind's thoughts and emotions in a detached and non-judgmental way in the fullness of the moment. The goal of mindfulness is to be more aware of our automatic and destructive responses so that we can make conscious choices. Mindfulness encapsulates the principles of non-judging, non-striving, patience, acceptance, letting go, trust, and having a beginner's mind. Many cultures and religions practice forms of mindfulness through meditation and prayer.

To help you be more mindful when communicating with others ask: "Am I defending myself or am I actually listening to what they are saying?" This question keeps us in the moment and reflecting on what is going on instead of reacting to our emotions and what we are telling ourselves is happening.

Tools

- Mindfulness: Focusing and Awareness
- Mindfulness Exercises
- Riding Out Your Emotion: Worry-Surfing
- Mindful Walking
- Focusing on an Object: Eating a Raisin

What is Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction?

Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR) was developed by Dr. Jon Kabat-Zinn at the University of Massachusetts Medical Center for patients suffering from pain. MBSR teaches individuals the principles of mindfulness and how to apply them to deal more effectively with stress, pain, illness, psychological distress and the demands of daily life. It teaches participants to respond to stressful situations "mindfully". MBSR has been extensively researched and found to be a helpful adjunct to conventional treatments for a variety of medical and psychological conditions, particularly anxiety, stress, depression, pain and weight management.

For a scientist's research paper on the positive effects of MBSR:

Grossman, P., Niemann, L., Schmidt, S. & Walach, H. (2004). Mindfulness-based stress reduction and health benefits: A meta-analysis. *Journal of Psychosomatic Research*, 57, 35-43.

MBSR Training Program

An 8-9 week program, MBSR training teaches mindfulness through breathing, body awareness exercises, sitting and walking meditation, and gentle yoga. The MBSR program is offered in many hospitals in the Toronto area, including [the MBSR Clinic](#) at St. Joseph's Health Centre.

There are also lots of private practitioners offering the program throughout Ontario. 'Mindful eating' is one of the latest additions to MBSR training, offering a non-diet way to lose weight. The Centre for Mindfulness offers a 'Mindfulness Weight Control Workshop'.

Stress management resource list

Counsellors at Queen's University Health, Counselling and Disability Services (HCDS) recently created a self-help workbook entitled *Your Best You: Improving Your Mood* specifically for Queen's students experiencing low mood.

You can download it for free by [accessing the HCDS website](#), or you can pay a small fee for a print copy.

Websites

[Stress.org](#). Links between stress and your health.

[Holistic Online](#). Information on stress and indepth strategies for coping with stress including alternative therapies.

[Stress Tips](#). Tips for how to cope with stress plus downloadable mp3s.

Books

David Posen, MD. Key Porter Books Ltd, Toronto. *The Little Book of Stress Relief* (2003) and *Staying Afloat When the Water Gets Rough* (1998)

Mind over Mood by Dennis Greenberger & Christine Padesky (1995). Includes many hands-on exercises and tools including the 'Thought Record'.

The Relaxation and Stress Reduction Workbook by M. Davis, E. Eshelman, & M. McKay. Now in its 5th edition (2000) this is still one of the best self-help books around.

Stress Less: Break the Power of Worry, Fear And Other Unhealthy Habits by Don Colbert, MD (2008). Latest information on the effects of stress on your body and ways to help you de-stress.

The Stress of Life by Hans Selye. The father of stress theory, Selye explains the medical effects of stress in his seminal work.

Resources on mindfulness

Dr. Jon Kabat-Zinn, the creator of Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction, outlines how to use 'mindfulness meditation' to reduce stress in the following books:

- *Full Catastrophe Living Using The Wisdom Of Your Body And Mind To Face Stress, Pain, And Illness* (1991)
- *Wherever You Go There You Are: Mindfulness Meditation in everyday life* (1995)

- *The Mindfulness & Acceptance Workbook for Anxiety* by Forsyth, J.P. & Eifert, G.H. (2007). Great self-directed book filled with practical exercises and a CD with scripted meditations.

Also see [the Centre for Mindfulness](#), [Wildmind.org](#), and [Mindfulness Meditation](#).

There are many others, too!

Journal articles

Brown, K.W., Ryan, R.M., Creswell, J.D. (2007). Mindfulness: Theoretical foundations and evidence for its salutary effects. *Psychological Inquiry*. 18(4). 211-237

Grossman, P., Niemann, L., Schmidt, S. & Walach, H. (2004). Mindfulness-based stress reduction and health benefits: A meta-analysis. *Journal of Psychosomatic Research*, 57, 35-43.

How well am I taking care of myself?

Rate yourself: 5= Frequently 4= Occasionally 3= Rarely 2= Never 1= Didn't occur to me

Physical self-care

- ☐ Eat regularly
- ☐ Eat healthfully
- ☐ Exercise
- ☐ Get regular medical check ups
- ☐ Get medical care when needed
- ☐ Take time off when sick
- ☐ Get massages/ body treatments
- ☐ Dance, swim, walk, run, play, etc
- ☐ Take time to be sexual
- ☐ Get enough sleep
- ☐ Wear clothes I like
- ☐ Take vacations
- ☐ Make time away from phones, computers

Other:

Emotional self-care

- ☐ Spend time in the company of those I enjoy
- ☐ Stay in touch with important people in my life
- ☐ Give myself affirmations, praise
- ☐ Love myself
- ☐ Revisit favourite books, movies
- ☐ Seek out comforting activities, objects, people, relationships, places
- ☐ Allow myself to cry
- ☐ Find things that make me laugh

Other:

Psychological self-care

- ☐ Make time for self-reflection
- ☐ Have my own personal counselling
- ☐ Write in a journal
- ☐ Read literature unrelated to school/work
- ☐ Try something I am not expert in or in charge of
- ☐ Notice my inner thoughts, judgements, beliefs, attitudes, feelings
- ☐ Let others know different aspects of myself
- ☐ Engage my intelligence in a new area

- ☐ Practice receiving from others
- ☐ Be curious
- ☐ Say 'no' to extra responsibilities when I need to
- Other:

Spiritual self-care

- ☐ Make time for reflection
- ☐ Spend time with nature
- ☐ Find a spiritual connection or community
- ☐ Be open to inspiration
- ☐ Be aware of non-material aspects of life
- ☐ Try at times not to be the expert or in charge
- ☐ Be open to not knowing
- ☐ Identify what is meaningful to me
- ☐ Meditate/pray
- ☐ Sing
- ☐ Have experiences of awe
- ☐ Contribute to causes in which I believe read or listen to inspirational literature
- Other:

School/ workplace self-care

- ☐ Take a break during the day
- ☐ Take time to chat with colleagues/ other students
- ☐ Make quiet time to complete tasks
- ☐ Identify exciting, rewarding projects
- ☐ Set limits with clients, colleagues, friends
- ☐ Arrange a comfortable work space
- ☐ Get regular feedback from mentors, supervisors, etc
- ☐ Negotiate my needs e.g. schoolwork, extension, deadlines, etc.
- ☐ Have a peer support group
- Other:

Balance

- ☐ Strive for balance within my academic and work life
- ☐ Strive for balance within my WHOLE life: family, relationships, school, play, rest.

ACTION PLAN:

From the activities above, highlight five you would like to start now.

Tension diary

Date	What increased my stress/tension? (e.g. event, person, mood, etc.)	Stress level (1=low stress, 10=high stress)	What did I do to decrease my stress/tension level?	How useful was this strategy? (1= not useful, 10=very useful)

Ten ways to relax your stress away

1. Breathe deeply.
2. Stretch. Try yoga or tai chi.
3. Exercise aerobically.
4. Take a warm bath.
5. Get a massage.
6. Eat healthfully.
7. Let it all out: Laugh, Cry, Sing, or Talk.
8. Have guilt-free fun.
9. Hang out with people who you can relax with.
10. Drink calming liquids e.g. chamomile tea, warm milk.



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Take a deep breath and relax

How deep breathing works

While babies breathe from the belly, adults tend to breathe from the chest causing shallower breathing. Consequently, less oxygen is taken in with each inhalation and the blood is forced to move through our system very quickly so that enough oxygen gets to the brain and organs. Deep breathing can reverse these effects.

Calming breath exercise: 5 in – 5 hold – 5 out

This breath exercise will help you achieve a deep state of relaxation quickly. Use it when you feel anxiety coming on. It will also reduce panic reactions such as hyperventilation. A note of caution: avoid taking excessively deep breaths repeatedly and stop the exercise if you feel faint.

1. Sit, stand, or lie down — up to you. If sitting, ensure both feet are planted on the floor. Wear loose, comfortable clothing.
2. Breathing from the abdomen, inhale slowly through the nose to the count of 5. 1...2...3...4...5 as you inhale. Imagine a balloon in your belly beginning to fill slowly with air. You may wish to put a hand on your belly to feel this sensation.
3. Pause and hold your breath for 5 breaths.
4. Exhale slowly, through the nose or mouth, to a count of 5. Feel the 'balloon' in your belly deflating slowly. Exhale fully.

Do this for about 2 minutes or more each time. As you relax more and more, you may increase the counting to 6, 7, or more.

Added options

- Use words
 - Use words on the inhalation and exhalation. E.G. Inhale say 'in' and exhale say 'out'. Try the word RELAX: Inhale say 're'; exhale say 'lax'.
- Use imagery
 - Adding a peaceful, safe scene to your breathing will increase the effect.
 - Imagine breathing in ocean air, the scent of the forest, a flower.

Effects of deep breathing

Because it releases the body's own painkillers (endorphins), deep breathing can relieve muscular-skeletal tension, headaches, stomach aches, and sleeplessness. It allows blood pressure to return to normal, which is good for your heart. Practice daily. By extending your practice to a month or longer, you will begin to retrain yourself to breathe from the abdomen.

Your breath goes with you wherever you go so you can use it anytime, anywhere.

Progressive muscle relaxation - script

This exercise asks you to tense and release various muscles. If you have a special problem with any muscle group, you can either skip that part or do it gently. You can keep your eyes open or closed, whichever is more comfortable. Take a moment to get comfortable. If you are in a chair, you may wish to uncross your arms and legs and ensure your back and neck are comfortable.

Feet & legs

Begin by lifting the feet slightly off the floor. Point your feet and curl the toes inward until the toes are scrunched into a little ball. Curl as far as you need to feel the tension without strain. Concentrate on the toes and count to 5. Now uncurl your toes and gently drop your feet to the floor. Feel the blood rushing into the feet, thighs and calves. Can you feel the difference between tension and relaxation?

Buttocks/low back

Next, slowly draw your knees together and imagine placing a penny between them. Explore the sensation of your knees pressing into the coin. Can you feel its edges? Its smooth, flat face? While you press, breathe in and out, slowly and evenly. Now hold for 5. And release. Study the difference between the tension and the relaxation in the buttock, low back, and pelvis.

Stomach

Imagine your navel. Take a deep breath in and watch the navel push outwards. Exhale evenly and pull the navel towards the spine till you have squeezed all the air from your lungs. Hold for 5. Release and let the navel settle into its normal resting place. Now let the breathing go back to its natural rhythm and the stomach totally relax. Relax into the heaviness of your stomach.

Shoulders

Shrug both shoulders up to the sky as high as they will go without straining. While you hold, listen to the tension. What is it saying to you? Hold for 5. Drop your shoulders back to their normal resting place and enjoy the calming breath. Allow the warmth and heaviness of the relaxation to suffuse this area.

Arms/Hands

Clench your fists and bend your elbows, bringing your fists towards your chest. While you hold be aware of the tension in your hands, forearms and biceps. Breathe in and out while you hold for 5. Now, open the hands slowly and feel the blood racing back into each finger. Study the warmth created by the fresh surge of blood or any other sensations you experience.

Facial muscles

Playfully make a big frown. Feel the corners of your mouth pull down till you look like a sad clown. At the same time, you may squint your eyes, clench your jaw and wrinkle up your nose. Whichever feels right for you. Enjoy imagining what you look like at this moment as you hold for 5. Let go and return to a relaxed expression. Be amazed by the softness of the face.

Conclusion

We are now finished relaxing the muscles of your body. You are now feeling completely relaxed and at peace. Let all residual tension leach out of your body slowly. If you find that there are places of tension, just note them. Then if you wish, breathe into those areas and let the breath help you loosen the tension.

Do-anywhere stretching exercises

These exercises take only a few moments, and can help melt away mental and muscle tension. For exercises in your chair, sit up straight, pelvis in neutral position, and feet flat on the floor.

Rag-Doll Dangle: Stand or sit, legs apart, and bend at the waist. Shake your arms and hands loosely. Let your head hang and sway. Slowly straighten, one vertebrae at a time.

Head Roll: Drop your chin to your chest. Rotate your head to the right and turn your chin to your shoulder. Repeat in the opposite direction.

Head Tilt: Keeping the shoulders down, tilt the left ear to the left shoulder. Place your left hand on the right side of the head and allow the weight to pull your head GENTLY to the side. Extend your right arm down and flex your right hand. Hold for 10. Repeat on the opposite side.

Head Nod: Let your head fall forward so your chin almost touches your chest. Link your hands and place them at the back of your head. Apply GENTLE pressure.

Head Lift: Curl your fingers around the sides of your neck, fingers meeting in the back. Lift straight upward and forward as though you were trying to lift your head off your shoulders. Turn your head slightly from right to left while you continue to lift.

Full Body: Extend your right arm straight up and reach as high as you can. Spread your fingers. Feel your right side stretching. Lower the arms and repeat with your left arm.

The Butterfly: Lace your fingers around the back of your head. Wing your arms wide and hold in place. Slowly bend forward until your chin is close to your chest. Hold. Come up slowly.

Pelvis Tilt: Tilt your pelvis forward so your lower back rounds, and then tip your pelvis backward so your lower back arches and your belly protrudes a little. Keep your neck, shoulders and stomach relaxed. Repeat several times slowly.

Basic Twist: Sit up straight on the edge of the chair. Slowly twist to the right side, turning your head in the same direction while keeping your shoulders relaxed. Observe how other muscles besides the twisting muscles near the spine jump into action. The right shoulder may rise up toward the ear or move backward. Relax more each time. Do the other side.

Basic Twist with Variation: Do the same slow twist to the right while turning the head to the left. This is impossible to do with hunched shoulders. An excessive arch in the lower back will also make it a struggle. Sit tall yet relaxed. Observe how muscles around the shoulders and chest may want to force the motion. Try to resist this, and activate only the twisting muscles.

Visualization: Springtime in the forest

You are walking in the forest in early spring. Allow yourself to feel the soft, moist ground of the earth under your feet. Drink in the dark, earthly colours grounding you with Nature. You see fresh young green shoots springing up from the moist earth after their winter hibernation. Allow yourself to be drawn closer to one of these shoots near to the earth's floor. Be interested in every detail of this little creation. Your hand reaches out to touch the leaves of a young plant. Perhaps a droplet of moisture clings to your finger like an infant to its mother. You draw your finger to your mouth and touch the droplet to your tongue. Allow your tongue to come alive with the replenishing liquid. Allow its hydrating properties to refresh your mouth as well as your spirit. You sense the warm sun touching the top of your head and it is time to continue on.

You might wish to stand up and stretch your body up to the sky, where the tops of the tall trees meet the vastness of the universe. Notice how the dark greens and browns of the trees contrast the oceanic blue of the sky. You hear the songs of birds flying overhead. Allow yourself to be one with Nature as you listen to what the birds are saying to you. Surrender to the stillness and quiet in the forest now.

Scan the soundscape for other noises and be amazed that there is life everywhere around you. Come alive with the feeling of being part of Nature's rebirth. You walk deeper into the forest's mysteries now and take deep invigorating breaths of the damp, cooling air. Your nostrils fill with Nature's springtime delights. Focus closely on subtle smells of what a new season brings--perhaps the sweet aroma of wildflowers or mossy peat. The heady smell makes you feel slightly giddy and fully alive.

Now it is time to leave the forest. You might wish to walk more briskly now. Notice how alive you feel with all the oxygen coursing through your veins. Even though it is time to leave this place, trust that you can hold onto the lessons of spring. Everything has a fresh new perspective. Allow the many possibilities in life to dance around you.

Written by Barbara Fretz, 2005

Using eye movements to reduce stress & improve recall

When a person is retelling a personal story, a lot of emotions arise. If you look closely at the person's eye movements, you will notice that he/she is periodically looking upwards. This involuntary action functions to reduce the stress associated by these emotions. When the stress is reduced, the mind can open up to more unconscious memory work (see Kevin Trudeau's 5 Stages of Information Processing in *Mega Memory*).

Activity

Here's the quickest way to relax and get out of the thinking stage:

1. Relax and take a breath.
2. Look up to the right and hold for a few seconds.
3. Look up to the left and hold for a few seconds.
4. Continue back and forth for a few seconds.

Trudeau, K. (1997). *Mega Memory: How to release your superpower memory in 30 minutes or less a day*. NY: HarperCollins.

12 rules for better sleep hygiene

1. Sleep as much as needed to feel refreshed but not more. Excessively long times in bed can lead to fragmented and shallow sleep.
2. Have a regular wake-up time in the morning. This strengthens circadian cycling and leads to regular times of sleep onset.
3. Exercise daily to deepen sleep. Occasional exercise does not necessarily improve sleep the following night.
4. Use a fan to provide background 'white noise' if occasional loud noises disturb your sleep.
5. Keep room temperature a little cool. Too hot or too cold rooms disturb sleep.
6. Hunger may disturb sleep so a light snack may help. Try low fat, non-spicy snacks.
7. An occasional sleeping pill may be of some benefit, but their chronic use is ineffective in most insomniacs.
8. Use deep breathing and muscle relaxation exercises to divert the mind from anxious thoughts and list making, which interfere with falling asleep.
9. Avoid caffeine, including coffee, tea, pop and chocolate. Caffeine disturbs sleep even in those who feel it does not.
10. Avoid alcohol. It may help tense people fall asleep more easily, but the ensuing sleep is then fragmented.
11. If you feel angry and frustrated because you can't sleep, don't try harder and harder to fall asleep. Turn on the light and do something different (but no electronics or rigorous exercise!).
12. Reduce number of cigarettes you smoke; chronic smoking disturbs sleep.

Adapted from "11 Rules for Better Sleep Hygiene" in Peter Hauri's (1982) book, *Current Concepts: The Sleep Disorders*.

How self-talk affects stress

Our internal dialogues or 'self-talk' direct our thoughts and behaviours. Becoming aware of your self-talk and how it affects you is the first step to rewriting or —reframing dialogues that cause you stress.

Positive or negative?

Self-talk is like a self-fulfilling prophecy, that is, if you think about something long enough, you can actually make it come true! So, when your self-talk is positive, (e.g. "I can get a good mark on the midterm"), you give yourself permission to be successful. Conversely, negative self-talk (e.g. "I'm lousy at math") can turn into you giving up on yourself and your chances of success.

Thoughts and behaviours

Self-talk can direct your thoughts and behaviours. For example, if you say "I can learn these problems to pass the physics test," you'll be more willing to put the effort—in even when it's tough going—and improve your chances of success.

Stress response

Negative self-talk can cause or increase your stress and our bodies respond with aches and pains (or worse!). Negative self-talk may also encourage you to behave foolishly or destructively, putting a further strain on your body. The good news is that positive self-talk has the opposite effect— it lowers stress and relaxes the body.

How to rewrite your script

1. Become aware of negative or destructive thoughts, especially longstanding ones.
2. Reframe your negative thought into a positive or more realistic one.
3. Repeat your new, positive thought as an affirmation or mantra. Eventually you will start to believe it.
4. Congratulate yourself for caring for yourself.

Source: *Self-Talk: How Self-Talk Affects Stress* from Parlay International.

[Parlay International](http://sass.queensu.ca/learningstrategies) provides information on health, education, safety and productivity training.

Identifying your stress-inducing self-talk

The next time you have a stress reaction (large or small), pause to analyze what thoughts were going through your mind about the situation, i.e., identify your 'self-talk'.

1. Write down some of the examples of your self-talk.

Consider...

- Why is this situation a problem for me?
- What's **really** upsetting me?
- What was I saying to myself that caused my stress to increase? Is my self-image or self-esteem feeling threatened?
- Am I feeling intimidated or rejected?
- What fears, beliefs, insecurities may be operating here?

2. Notice if there are any patterns to your self-talk (bet there is!)

3. Notice whether your stress level lowers after you understand why you got upset.

Adapted from: Posen, D. (2003). *The Little Book of Stress Relief*. Toronto: Key Porter Books Ltd.

Thought Record for reframing negative thoughts

Situation	Mood	Automatic thoughts (images)	Evidence that supports the hot thought	Evidence that does not support the hot thought	Alternative/ balanced thoughts	Rate moods now
Who were you with? What were you doing? When was it? Where were you?	Describe each mood in one word. Rate intensity of mood (0-100%)	Answer some or all of the following questions: What was going through my mind just before I started to feel this way? What does this say about me? What does this mean about me? My life? My future? What am I afraid might happen? What is the worst thing that could happen if this is true? What does this mean about how the other person(s) feel(s)/ think(s) about me? What does this mean about how the other person(s) feel(s)/think(s) about me? What does this mean about the person(s) or people in general? What images or memories do I have in this situation?	Circle hot thought in previous column for which you are looking for evidence. Write factual evidence to support this conclusion. (Try to avoid mind-reading and interpretation of facts.)	Ask yourself the questions in the Hint Box to help discover evidence which does not support your hot thought.	Ask yourself the questions in the Hint Box to generate alternative or balanced thoughts. Write an alternative or balanced thought. Rate how much you believe in each alternative or balanced thought (0-100%).	Copy the feelings from Colum 2. Rate the intensity of each feeling from 0-100% as well as any new records.

How to use the Thought Record

Column 1 Situation: Write down your anxiety-provoking situation.

Column 2 Moods: Describe what you felt (e.g. panic, anxiety) and rate each mood's intensity 1-100%.

Column 3 Automatic Thoughts: Write down what was going through your mind, including images, just before you started to feel this way. Then, circle the 'hot thought,' i.e., the thought that caused your anxiety to peak. *Column 4 Evidence 'For':* Starting with the 'hot thought' you circled in

Column 3, look for **factual** evidence that supports this conclusion. Try to avoid interpretation of facts.

Column 5 Evidence 'Against': **Now look for evidence which does not support your hot thought.** If you are having a hard time finding this evidence, try asking: "If my best friend or someone who loves me knew I was having this thought, what would they say to me?"

Column 6 Alternative Thoughts: **Now look at the evidence, for and against. If the evidence does not support your hot thought(s), ask "Is there an alternative way to thinking about or understanding this situation?"** Write an alternative view of the situation.

* If your hot thought is partially true, combine the evidence, for and against, into a balanced thought. e.g. Hot thought: "I can't get this thesis done." Balanced thought: "Writing a thesis is a large project, but I have completed other projects of this scale in the past."

** If your hot thought is true, ask: What is the worst outcome? What is the best outcome? What is the most realistic outcome?

Column 7 Rate New Moods: Finally, rerate the intensity of each feeling and compare to the intensity in Column 2.

You might notice that the mood's intensity has decreased.

Source: Greenberger, D. & Padesky, C.A. (1995). *Mind Over Mood*. NY: The Guilford Press.

Stress Inoculation Training

Stress inoculation procedure

Prepare

i) **An anxiety hierarchy:** Before practicing this procedure, build an anxiety hierarchy, from least to most anxiety-provoking scenarios. Using this hierarchy will help you learn to cope with increasingly stressful situations.

ii) **Coping statements:** Choose coping statements to say to yourself before, during and after the interaction or stress situation. For a list of example coping statements, go to [the Coping Statements tool](#) in our [Managing Stress at University module](#).

1. Before: Preparing for the situation
2. During: Confronting the situation
3. During: Coping with negative effects
4. After: Reinforcement: Reward yourself even though you were very anxious about it.

Practice

i) Get mentally and physically relaxed: e.g. deep breathing, muscle relaxation, imagining

ii) Visualize the first scene in the anxiety hierarchy: Describe your anxiety-provoking situation as clearly and with as much detail as possible

Identify escape routes

iii) Start to cope: Once the visualized scene is clear in your mind, begin relaxing and using your coping statements/ thoughts. Continue for 30-60 seconds –unless anxiety becomes too high.

iv) Rate your anxiety 0 to 10 (0 = no anxiety 10 = major panic attack)

v) Do more deep relaxation as you picture yourself successfully handling the situation. vi) Repeat above.

vii) Rate your anxiety 0 to 10.

viii) When anxiety is low, move onto the next most stressful scene in the hierarchy. Don't forget to reward yourself for having the courage to try new ways of coping with stress.

Stress Inoculation Training: Coping statements

Although it's better to create your own stress-coping statement and memorize them, here are some examples to get you started. These coping statements were designed as part of Meichenbaum's Stress Inoculation Training program.

1. Preparation

- There's nothing to worry about. I'm going to be all right.
- I've succeeded with this before.
- I know I can do each one of these tasks.
- It's easier once I get started. I'll jump in and be all right. Tomorrow I'll be through it.

2. Confronting the situation

- Stay organized
- Take it step by step.
- I can do this; I'm doing it now.
- I can only do my best.
- Any tension I feel is a signal to use my coping exercises. I can get help if I need it.
- If I don't think about fear, I won't be afraid.
- If I get tense, I'll take a breather and relax.

3. Coping with negative effects

- Relax now!
- Just breathe deeply.
- There's an end to it.
- Keep my mind on the task at hand.
- I can keep this within limits I can handle. I can always call _____.
- I am only afraid if I decide to be. I can decide not to be.
- I've survived this and worse before.
- Being active will lessen the fear.

4. Reinforcing success

- I did all right. I did well.
- Next time I won't have to worry so much.
- I am able to relax away anxiety.
- It's possible not to be scared. All I have to do is stop thinking I'm scared.

Source: Davis, M., Eshelma, E.R. & McKay, M. (2000). 5th edition. *The Relaxation & Stress Reduction Workbook*. Oakland, CA: New Harbinger Publications.

A grad student scenario using stress inoculation

JD has been working on his doctoral thesis for the past 6 years and is close to the deadline. During this time JD has had two children, and experienced a number of significant life stresses. JD is generally a good student, but due to life circumstances, needs a 12 month extension. About 6 months ago JD approached his supervisor and indicated that he might need an extension. The supervisor responded with —don't be ridiculous, a bright guy like you shouldn't need an extension. Just buckle down and focus . JD hopes to graduate and pursue an academic career. The supervisor is well respected in his field and JD is dependent on his recommendation.

Since that time JD has avoided the supervisor, including e-mails, telephone calls etc and only comes to the department when the supervisor is away. JD feels highly anxious when thinking about the supervisor. JD keeps thinking that the supervisor will think he is an idiot if he needs an extension, despite the fact that the supervisor has told JD that he thinks his thesis is excellent. JD has continued to work on his thesis, but realistically will need another 12 months. JD needs to contact his supervisor, request an extension and assure the supervisor of his continued commitment to graduate work.

Scenario written by: Dr. Nina Josefowitz, Department of Counselling Psychology, OISE/University of Toronto.

JD's Anxiety Hierarchy

Easiest: He is thinking about asking his supervisor for another meeting to discuss a thesis extension.

He decides to email the supervisor and arrange a meeting time. He gets a voicemail from his supervisor confirming the meeting.

He sees the supervisor coming down the hallway, headed in his direction. He keeps walking towards him till they meet. Supervisor says he'll see JD tomorrow.

He is sitting in the supervisor's office. He asks JD what he would like to talk about.

He begins by reiterating the events leading up to getting behind schedule. The professor is listening to him.

He asks the supervisor for a 12-month extension but the professor expresses reservations about giving him such a long extension.

Most difficult: He sticks to his guns about the 12-month extension explaining again that he really needs a full year. The professor doesn't budge.

Rating: JD scales his anxiety pre and post imaginal exposure from 0 to 10.

JD's cognitive coping script

Using the most difficult scene in his hierarchy.

BEFORE: Preparing for a stressor

JD is walking to the supervisor's office where he will ask for an extension. He imagines the supervisor very busy and not wanting to be interrupted. He imagines himself ready to knock on the professor's door.

"What do I have to do?... When I get there, just think about the situation, not my anxiety... If my supervisor appears busy, I will give him a moment to wind up what he is doing and in the meantime I will focus on my breathing...I can be anxious and still deal with this situation... I will think rationally and not allow my anxiety to take over... My supervisor has gone to bat for me in the past so there is no reason he won't today...I am confident that I will ask him exactly what I need—a 12 month extension on my thesis...Breathe and relax...I am ready for this challenge."

DURING

JD imagines asking for the extension.

a) Confronting and handling a stressor

"I ask for an extension...Relax. I am in control. Take a deep breath... The supervisor is having reservations about my request...That's OK; he has a right to his thoughts and opinions...Think about what you want to say right now...Keep my mind on my goals and needs...If my supervisor denies my request for the twelve months extension, I have some alternatives for negotiation...I can handle this situation...I am still in control...Keeping focusing on the breath."

b) Coping with Negative Affect

JD imagines that his supervisor will criticize his commitment to graduate work as he has done in the past.

"This is very upsetting but I am not going to let him get to me...My muscles are getting tight. Take a deep breath and slow things down...Reiterate how important this thesis is to me and how much I love the research... I can be anxious and still deal with this situation...Time to slow down...I am confident I can convince him that I am totally committed to this work...Breathe into my belly and feel deep relaxation...I can get what I want by staying calm and not getting defensive...That's right."

AFTER: Reinforcing

JD is imagining that the supervisor agrees to a shorter extension of 10 months:

“It worked; I did it! I did not get a full 12 month extension but I can live with that...Good for me...I have been able to keep this supervisor who is important to my future academic life... I handled this situation pretty well...Wait until I tell my wife.”

JD is imagining that the supervisor doesn't agree to any extension:

“It didn't work. That's okay. I handled it pretty well. I am still pleased that I spoke my mind.”

Ways to accept

Love your problems

Accept the problem by experiencing it, telling the truth about it, describing it in detail.

Unconditional acceptance: this is not giving in to the problem, or giving up, but is a way to be with it and get to know it.

Loving your problem frees you from it by draining it of its power, rather than denying its existence or struggling against it.

Surrender

Reach for help when you feel the problem is too big to handle by yourself. Trying to control a problem can result in the problem controlling you.

Surrendering is not quitting, or resignation. You can use your resources to handle the problem and then surrender (e.g. to the outcome) with a trusting spirit. Surrender to a higher power or to the self.

Detach and watch from a distance without judgment. Letting things happen rather than making things happen leads to inner peace.

Celebrate your mistakes

Celebrating allows us to notice the mistake. Mistakes are valuable feedback.

Mistakes demonstrate that we're taking risks and are willing to learn and grow.

Celebrating mistakes reminds us that it's OK to make them.

Celebrating mistakes includes everyone.

Mistakes occur only when we aim at a clear goal.

Mistakes happen only when we're committed to making things work.

Celebrating mistakes cuts the problem down to size.

Source: Ellis, D. (2000). *Becoming a Master Student*. Canadian 3rd Edition. Boston: Houghton Mifflin. pp 186-87.

Mindfulness: Focusing & awareness

Mindfulness incorporates both focusing and awareness. Focusing is an excellent place to start training your mind. In order to change, though, you will want to shift from focusing to becoming more aware of thoughts and feelings. At any time you may go back to focusing.



Focusing

Inward: “eyes on the road”

Anchor on an object (e.g. breath) to keep the mind centred

Awareness

Outward: seeing thoughts and feelings from the outside. You see yourself and your mental dynamics in more detail from this perspective. You notice things you’ve never seen before.

“Seeing the scenery”: watching the mental traffic as if it belongs to someone else.

Imagine the mind as a stream of consciousness. When there is a deluge of thoughts and sensations and you are at risk of being drowned in the stream, that’s when focusing comes in.

Shifting emphasis from focusing to awareness

- a) watch the stream of consciousness, dispassionately
- b) pluck something from the stream and deliberately focus on it (e.g. a dream image, a memory, a pain)

Awareness exercise

Start by taking your mind inwards for a moment by focusing on the breath. Take a few gentle deep breaths, from the belly. In and out. Relax... Continue to breathe for as long as you wish.

Now take your mind outwards. See your thoughts, feelings, moods, and sensations as objects floating down a stream, coming into view and vanishing from sight. Simply watch without judgment or analysis. Just watch them pass by.

Now pluck one of these objects from the stream and take a moment to focus on it. Let the other sensations and thoughts go by in the background. Note any new thoughts or feelings that arise from observing this object. Sit with these thoughts/feelings for a moment.

Whenever you are ready to leave this object behind, simply deposit it on a leaf and let it float downstream.

Mindfulness exercises

Focusing exercises

Practice focusing every day. It will help you learn to stay in the moment in your everyday life.

See [Take a Deep Breath and Relax](#) in the [Managing Stress at University module](#).

1. **Body Scan:** Lie down with your eyes closed. Slowly scan up and down your body for tightness/ soreness. If you find a tight spot, stop and breathe into it until it relaxes. You might also imagine healing, white light radiating into the spot.
2. **Object Meditation:** Choose a favourite or interesting object e.g. a stone, a flower. Spend some time observing the object: its shape, hues, textures, smells, tastes. Go for detail.
3. **Mindful Eating:** eating slowly, mindfully. Be aware of all the sensations of the food: taste, texture, sounds, weight.
4. **Walking Meditation:** While you walk, focus on sensations of the body moving. Soften the eyes and look at the ground a few paces ahead of you. Pay attention to how you walk. Aim to walk with no tension: relax into it, letting your hips and shoulders swing easily. Breathe with your footsteps. It can help to scan your body as you walk allowing the movement to free up tensions. You may also consider saying a mantra or affirmation in time with the steps.
5. **Mindful stretching** e.g. slow, gentle Hatha yoga

Awareness exercises

1. Simply watching

This is a particularly useful activity when your mind is very busy and you are finding focusing difficult. Watch the passing thoughts without judging them. Just watch them like the clouds passing by. Identify (or say out loud) each thought, feeling, and sensation that comes up: e.g. sore neck, pizza, best friend, anger, tingling, empty stomach, pizza again, grandma, I miss her...

2. Practice new thought statements to detach:

Thought are not facts. I am not my thoughts.

3. “Urge Surfing” for cravings and urges.

Be aware of the warning signs, i.e. the urge or craving is approaching. Imagine the wave as an urge, i.e. the urge crests then falls. Ride the wave without giving into the urge. Let the urge pass. Celebrate your effort to ride through the urge. Accept that new urges will appear.

Riding out your emotions: worry surfing

Imagine for a moment an ocean wave as it approaches the shore. It's steep and tall and hasn't crested yet into a breaker. Now imagine the wave nearing a group of gulls floating on the water. The birds don't fly away. They simply ride up the facing slope, round the top, and drift down the long back of the wave.

That's what you can learn to do with your worries, anxieties, and fears (WAFs). All emotions are wave-like and time limited. They ebb and flow. Life's a wave: emotions build up, eventually reach a peak, and drift away. WAFs come and go in a similar way. They don't last forever, even if it feels like they will.

In this exercise we will invite you to ride the wave of one of your WAFs.

Exercise

Now think of a recent event where you felt afraid, panicky, nervous, worried, or upset. Visualize the scene and remember how you felt. Notice the worrying and disconcerting thoughts. Perhaps you'll notice images of disaster, too. Keep focusing on the upsetting scene as well as on the judgments you make about it and what is happening inside you.

Let your anxiety rise till it's at least a 4 or 5 on a scale of 10.

Observe what your body might be doing. Notice the sensations and how your mind evaluates them. Simply label them all with "I am noticing...". Notice the sensations of warmth and tightness. If there's a thought that it's dangerous, that you're losing control, just let your body and mind do their thing.

As you do this, notice the emotional wave in the room with you. At this point, the wave is tall and scary. You may feel that it will go on forever; that you may drown. Just allow the wave to run its course without controlling or blocking it. If you refuse to ride out the wave and try to fight it, you'll never get over the top. You'll stay stuck on the wave's leading edge.

Notice the emotional wave with you. Be aware of the point where it stops climbing. Feel it leveling off and starting to diminish. Experience the slow ride down the back of the wave. Accept wherever you are on the wave. Don't hasten to get past it. It moves at its own speed — all you can do is let go and let it carry you.

Keep watching this until it completely passes.

Source: Forsyth, J.P. & Eifert, G.H. (2007). *The Mindfulness & Acceptance Workbook for Anxiety*. Oakland, CA: New Harbinger Publications, Inc.

Mindful walking

Meditation is about being present. It is all about slowing up, about being fully present to your life, as it is right now, without trying to change it in any way. You'll be glad to know that mindfulness is not all about closing your eyes and focusing on your breath all day long.

Just remember... there are no expectations. This exercise is mindful and that means that you remain detached and non-judgmental of whatever comes to mind. If you find this hard, be mindful of your (perceived lack of) mindfulness. Doing a mindfulness exercise means you're doing it right – so you can't go wrong.

Some people use walking meditation instead of breathing meditation. All you do in walking meditation is walk and focus on the sensation of walking. That is your focus as opposed to your breath. In walking meditation, you are not trying to get anywhere. To reinforce this, you walk in circles around a room or up and down a hall. This gives your mind the message that there's no use hurrying since you are not going anywhere anyway. Walking is generally a relaxing experience for both mind and body, and an excellent way to release stress or restless energy.

You can begin by focusing on your legs, feet or your whole body. It isn't the walking speed that matters so much as focusing fully on the activity. Some people find it helpful to slow their walking and pay attention to each part of each step while others wobble when slow and need to speed things up. Just go with whatever feels right to you.

If your mind wanders from the focus, notice where it has gone, then respectfully escort it back to the walking. People who are agitated may find walking meditation a good meditation to do (there's a reason we pace when we're agitated). Preferably do your mindfulness activities in a private spot, either in your home or in your yard.

Now let's start...

Stand straight, head up, feet about shoulder width. You're forming a solid stance, firm base.

Feel your balance, how you're shifting slightly back and forth, from side to side. Normally this happens automatically. Become aware of these minor movements.

Feel the soles of your feet, roll gently back and forth to emphasize the sensation of your feet against the ground.

Focus on a point in front of you. It's time for your first step...

Rolling forwards, push off with your right foot and s-l-o-w-l-y take a step.

For a couple of seconds, feel how your leg moves through the air. The sensation of impact as your heel touches the ground.

Slow, fluid movements...

Now push off with your left leg. Feel how your right leg muscles are balancing your body as your left leg travels through the air and touches the ground.

Take 5 slow, fluid steps like this. Then halt and turn around. Now walk back to your starting point, close to normal speed this time. Did you feel the difference? This time you relied more on sight and less on feeling your balance and your senses didn't you?

Slowing down the pace, we tend to become aware of other, lesser used senses. Now repeat the slow walk and return.

Let's have some fun.

Pretend to be running in slow-motion. You're now the hero of a movie chasing down the bad guy. OR pretend you are a model walking in slow-motion down the catwalk. Walk, look... and turn!

After you're done stand still for a minute and feel your mind and body.

Simply observe any sensations or feelings. Whenever you become aware of any thoughts or sensations, remain mindful and detached and let the sensations go. When a new thought or sensation comes, let that one go.

Become aware of the gentle, fluid movements within your mind.

Thoughts and sensations are replaced by other thoughts and sensations - a perpetual, impermanent cycle. This is natural, just as the moving, changing sensations in your body, coming and going as you walk.

Final thoughts

Hopefully your mind enjoyed the break from habitual patterns and thinking about what-to-do-next. You didn't walk, you were just moving. Mindfulness is more about living than exercising. If you can learn to establish awareness during walking meditation—when you are physically moving with your eyes open—then it won't be difficult to arouse that same wakeful quality during other activities, such as eating, washing dishes or driving. It will be easier for you to arouse mindfulness when you walk to your car or during any other time. Your mindfulness will become a habit that will begin to permeate your entire life.

Sources:

- [Mindfulness Activities in Slo-o-ow Motion](#)
- [Mindful Nature Walking \(One Step at a Time\)](#)

Mindful eating: A raisin

1. Hold the raisin in the palm of your hand. Feel the weight of it.
2. Look at this raisin. Notice any unique features of your raisin. Let your eyes explore every part examine the highlights where light shines, its crevasses, its folds and ridges.
3. Hold the raisin between your fingers and turn it. Notice its texture.
4. Hold the raisin to your ear. Squish it a bit. Does it make a sound? Take note of any sensations that you feel.
5. Hold the raisin beneath your nose, and with each inhalation drink in every smell, noticing as you do this if there is anything happening in your mouth or stomach.
6. Notice your thoughts (for instance, like or dislike) without trying to push them away.
7. With awareness, slowly bring the raisin to your lips, noticing how your hand and arm know where to be, perhaps noticing saliva as you bring the raisin to your mouth.
8. Gently place the raisin in your mouth, without chewing noticing how it gets into the mouth in the first place. Spend a few moments exploring the sensations of having it in your mouth, exploring it with your tongue.
9. Notice to which side your tongue pushes the raisin.
10. When you are ready prepare to chew the raisin.
11. Then very consciously, take one or two bites into the raisin and notice what happens in the aftermath, experiencing any waves of taste as you continue chewing.
12. Resist the urge to swallow. Notice the sensation of taste-the juice and texture of the raisin and how these change over time, as well as any changes in the raisin itself.
13. See if you can first detect the intention to swallow as it comes up, so that you experience this sensation consciously before you actually swallow the raisin.
14. Finally, swallow the raisin – see if you can feel it going down towards your stomach and even entering your stomach. Perhaps noticing what it feels like to be one raisin heavier.
15. Sense how the body as a whole feels after completing this exercise.

What did you notice, what did you like/dislike about the activity?

What might you do to notice the food you eat? How could you invite intimacy in the moment while eating? How would this change mealtimes? How about at other times of the day?

There is nothing magical about mindfulness. Often when we do one task, we are already thinking of the next task. Most of us do different things while we eat – talk or watch television.

Notice how slowing down and tasting your food helps bring you into the present moment and can change the nature of your experience.

Though it sounds simple, mindfulness takes practice, and the longer you practice the easier the process becomes.